06 ISSUE

ISSUE 06 · THE RECKONING BETWEEN KNOWING & DOING

Drowning in Paper

The institutions are not failing for want of knowledge. They are failing under the weight of it. The money that hid the gap has gone, and what is left is the question they could always postpone: not what to think, but what to do.

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The order to leave was signed on a Monday, and by the inauguration the work had stopped. Within months ninety percent of one agency's contracts were gone, and the largest single provider of humanitarian funding the world has known was being folded into a filing cabinet. I have spent fifteen years inside the programmes that money was meant to make work, so I read the collapse differently from the people announcing it. What is ending is not only the funding. It is the era in which an institution could answer a hard question with another report.

The numbers are now confirmed rather than feared. Official development assistance fell by 23.1 percent in 2025, the steepest single-year contraction the OECD has ever recorded, with the United States alone responsible for three quarters of the drop.[1] Aid to sub-Saharan Africa fell by more than a quarter. Humanitarian funding fell by more than a third. The system that took eighty years to assemble lost a fifth of itself in a single year, and the projections for the year ahead point downward again.

I want to say plainly what most of the commentary steps around. This is a catastrophe for the people at the end of the chain, and it is also a reckoning the institutions postponed for decades and can no longer avoid. Both things are true. The grief and the diagnosis belong in the same sentence, because the second is the only route out of the first.

THE THING THE MONEY WAS HIDING

For as long as the budgets grew, an institution under pressure had a reliable move. Commission a study. Publish a framework. Add a strategy to the portfolio of strategies. The output looked like action and postponed the harder question of whether anything changed on the ground. Funding made the substitution affordable. When you can always do more, you never have to ask whether what you did worked.

The clearest evidence for this sits inside the institutions themselves. The World Bank examined sixteen hundred of its own policy reports and found that nearly a third had never been downloaded even once, and that eighty-seven percent were never cited by anyone, anywhere.[2] Not read late. Not read poorly. Never opened. An institution producing knowledge at industrial scale and consuming almost none of it. That is not an accident of distribution. It is the signature of a system that had confused producing knowledge with using it.

This is not one institution's failing. The scholars who study it have a name for the mechanism. Policy accumulation, the continuous addition of new commitments to existing portfolios without ever retiring the old, until the rate of production so far exceeds the rate of completion that the bureaucracy beneath simply cannot carry the load.[3] The same researchers show what follows. Implementation collapses not because the policies are wrong but because there are too many of them for any capacity to execute. The library grows. The delivery does not.

The deeper truth, the one the discipline has circled for forty years, is that evidence does not move institutions the way the institutions claim it does. The political scientists who have studied this most closely conclude that evidence-based policy is closer to a slogan than a description, that it is unusual for new evidence to have a direct or immediate effect on what anyone decides.[4] More information was never the missing ingredient. An institution does not fail to act because it lacks the study. It fails to act because knowing and doing are different faculties, and it had been investing in only one of them.

WHERE THE GAP IS MEASURED IN LIVES

On my own terrain the abstraction becomes unbearable. Humanitarian funding for the Sahel fell to its lowest level in a decade, with under a third of the requirement met in 2025.[5] In one country, where rations were cut because the money ran short, acute hunger surged by sixty-four percent in two years. In the communities that kept full rations, hunger fell by thirty-four percent over the same period.[6] Two figures, one cause. The knowledge of what to do was never in doubt. Food was the intervention, and everyone knew it. The only variable was whether the thing known was actually delivered.

That is the whole argument in a single comparison. Not a gap in understanding. A gap between understanding and execution, and the gap is where people fall. The reports on Sahel food security fill shelves. The shelves did not feed anyone. The ration did, where it arrived, and the surge in hunger marks precisely where it did not.

> *“The library grows. The delivery does not.”*

WHY NOTHING IS COMING TO THE RESCUE

The hope quietly entertained in many institutions is that private money will step into the hole. It will not, and the arithmetic is not close. The agency that was dismantled moved on the order of forty billion dollars a year. Total development giving by American foundations runs at roughly six billion a year.[7] The heads of the largest health philanthropies have said so directly, in public, that no foundation and no individual can replace funding at the scale of a state.[8] The replacement everyone is counting on is mathematically impossible, and the people closest to the money are the ones saying it loudest.

There is a second reason the rescue is not coming, and it is quieter and worse. The institutions with money to give have grown cautious about being seen to oppose the power dismantling the system, because that power has shown it will punish those who cross it, university by university, firm by firm.[9] So the funders who could speak are calculating the cost of speaking. A gap of money is survivable. A gap of nerve, at the moment the system most needs defenders, is something else.

WHAT SURVIVAL ACTUALLY ASKS

So the institutions face the question the funding let them defer. Not what more to know. What to do with what they already know, and how to do it with far less. I have answered a version of this question before, on a smaller stage, and the answer did not come from a strategy document.

In 2018 I was given a distressed programme in Dakar that every report described as functional and every person on the ground knew was finished. It was saved by one move above all others. The authority to decide was returned to the people closest to the work, who had always known what to do and had never been permitted to do it. The knowledge had been present the entire time. What was missing was the permission, and the structure that kept the permission far from the ground.

This is why the one reform that matters is also the one the sector has promised for a decade and never delivered. The commitment to move a quarter of humanitarian funding to local and national actors, made in 2016, stands today at three and a half percent reaching them directly.[10] Nine years of communiqués, and the share that reaches the people who actually carry the work has barely moved. The knowing was never the problem here either. The doing was.

I will not pretend localisation is a magic word. It is too often used to describe programmes that look like reform while leaving every real dependency intact.[11] Returning authority is not a slogan to be printed. It is a transfer of power that the holders of power resist, which is exactly why it appears in every strategy and almost no budget. But the crisis has done what a decade of good intentions could not. It has made the expensive, top-heavy, knowledge-hoarding model unaffordable, and an institution that cannot afford to hold all the authority at the centre may finally be forced to let it go.

> *“The crisis is not the thing to survive. It is the thing forcing the cure.”*

That is the opportunity hidden inside the catastrophe, and I state it without comfort. The institutions that survive the next five years will not be the ones with the best research or the largest libraries of policy. They will be the ones that close the distance between what they know and what they do, that measure delivery rather than activity, and that push authority down to where the work actually happens. The reckoning is brutal and it is also clarifying. What could be hidden under a growing budget cannot be hidden under a shrinking one.

THE CHOICE, NAMED

An institution that responds to a survival crisis by commissioning a study of the survival crisis has learned nothing, and there will be many of them. They will produce the framework, hold the convening, publish the lessons, and call the production a response. It is the only move the old model knows, and the money to sustain it is gone.

The alternative is harder and it is the only one that lives. Read less and decide more. Retire the strategies you will never execute. Stop counting reports written and meetings held, and start counting whether a ration arrived, whether a clinic opened, whether the decision sat with the person close enough to the work to make it well. None of this is new knowledge. It is the oldest knowledge in the field, the knowledge a budget allowed everyone to ignore. The institutions that remember it will survive the decade. The ones that answer the reckoning with another report will not, and they will have the studies to prove they saw it coming.

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REFERENCES & A NOTE ON THE EVIDENCE

An essay written from practice and tested against the current data and scholarship. Figures are drawn from authoritative 2025-2026 sources; aid totals for 2025 are OECD preliminary data and subject to revision. Projected mortality figures from the funding cuts are peer-reviewed models with wide uncertainty intervals, not confirmed counts, and are contested by the administration responsible for the cuts.

[1] OECD (April 2026), preliminary 2025 ODA data: total -23.1% to USD 174.3 bn, the largest annual contraction on record; US ODA -56.9%; sub-Saharan Africa bilateral -26.3%; humanitarian -35.8%.

[2] Doemeland, D. & Trevino, J. (2014). Which World Bank Reports Are Widely Read? World Bank Policy Research Working Paper 6851. 31% of 1,611 reports never downloaded; 87% never cited.

[3] Adam, Hurka, Knill & Steinebach (2019), Policy Accumulation and the Democratic Responsiveness Trap, Cambridge University Press; and Knill, Steinebach & Zink (2024), JEPP, on implementation overload.

[4] Cairney, P. (2016), The Politics of Evidence-Based Policy Making; Cairney & Oliver (2017); Oliver, Lorenc & Innvær (2014), Health Research Policy and Systems 12:34.

[5] OCHA (2025-2026), West and Central Africa: Sahel humanitarian funding at its lowest in a decade, ~29% of requirements met.

[6] WFP field data, Mali (2023-2025): areas with ration cuts saw a 64% rise in acute hunger (IPC 3+); areas retaining full rations saw a 34% decrease.

[7] Center for Global Development, Foundations in a World of Falling Aid Flows; OECD estimate of US foundation development giving ~USD 6bn/year against USAID throughput an order of magnitude larger.

[8] John-Arne Røttingen (Wellcome Trust) and the Gates Foundation leadership, public statements 2025: philanthropy cannot fill the gap left by state funding.

[9] Reporting 2025 on the chilling effect: federal funding freezes and tax-status threats against universities (Harvard, Columbia, Johns Hopkins) and executive orders against law firms, several ruled unconstitutional retaliation.

[10] ALNAP, Global Humanitarian Assistance Report 2025: 3.6% of humanitarian funding to local/national actors directly (7.5% including indirect), against the 2016 Grand Bargain 25% commitment.

[11] Onyekwena, O. (Gates Foundation, 2025): caution that localisation and self-reliance often describe the appearance of reform while leaving structures of dependency untouched.